

 Official website of the Department of Homeland Security

On July 17, 2026, DHS [published](#) a final rule establishing a fixed time period for academic students, J exchange visitors and representatives of foreign information.



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SEVIS HELP HUB

F-1 Optional Practical Training (OPT)

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[F-1 Optional Practical Training \(OPT\)](#)

F-1 OPTIONAL PRACTICAL TRAINING (OPT)

Last updated: May 19, 2025

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F-1 students often want to work. However, employment opportunities are limited, and strict rules apply. This document discusses different types of optional practical training (OPT) including: required forms, processes, and updating SEVIS.

What is Optional Practical Training?

Optional practical training is one type of work permission available for eligible F-1 students. It allows students to get real-world work experience related to their field of study.

While a Designated School Official (DSO) recommends OPT in SEVIS, it is the student who must apply for the work permit with the U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Service (USCIS). If the OPT is approved, USCIS will issue an Employment Authorization Document (EAD). The student must not begin working before the start date on the EAD.

Regulations and Policy Guidance

Complex rules and guidance apply to OPT. Any OPT requests entered into SEVIS must comply with federal regulations. DSOs must understand the following regulations and policy guidance:

Planning
Tool for
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Student
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F-1 Off
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F-1
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**F-1
Optional
Practical
Training
(OPT)**



8 Code of Federal
Regulations (CFR) 214.2(f)
(10) through (13)
8 CFR 274a.12(c)(3)
[SEVP Policy Guidance on
OPT](#)
[SEVP Policy Guidance:
Practical Training –
Determining a Direct
Relationship between
Employment and a Student’s
Major Area of Study](#)

OPT Types

There are three general types of OPT:

Type	Description
OPT	For students engaged in post-secondary schools or at conservatories. Twelve months of Regular OPT is available for each higher level of study. (For example a student may have 12 months for a bachelor’s degree and another 12 months for a master’s degree.) • Pre-Completion OPT: Any portion of OPT used <i>before</i> the student’s Program End Date. It may be part-time or full-

F-1 Add,
Edit,
Delete
Optional
Practical
Training
(OPT)
Employer

F-1 STEM
Optional
Practical
Training
(OPT)
Extension

M-1
Practical
Training

SEVIS
and the
SEVP
Portal

Manage
Program
Dates,
Registration
and Course
Load

Transfers

Update
Student
Records

	time. • Post-Completion OPT: Any portion of OPT used <i>after</i> the student’s Program End Date. It must be at least 20 hours per week or full-time.
<u>24-month (STEM) OPT Extension</u>	For students who majored in designated Science, Technology, Engineering, and Math (STEM) degrees approved by DHS. This type of OPT is a 24-month extension of OPT.
<u>Cap-Gap OPT Extension</u>	For students whose prospective employers filed a qualifying H-1B-cap subject petition.

SEVIS Basics
School Records

OPT Request Statuses

The table below lists the statuses used to identify the stages of OPT requests in SEVIS.

Status	Status Meaning
Requested	DSO requested OPT in SEVIS on behalf of the student, but USCIS has not yet received the Application for Employment Authorization (Form I-765).
Pending	USCIS has received the Form I-765.
Approved	USCIS has approved the Form I-765.
Denied	USCIS has denied the Form I-765.

Canceled	DSO or a scheduled SEVIS maintenance job canceled the practical training request in SEVIS.
Withdrawn	USCIS approved the student's request to withdraw the Form I-765.

OPT Eligibility

A student is eligible for OPT if:

- The student has been a full-time student for one academic year in an SEVP-certified:
 - College
 - University
 - Conservatory
 - Seminary
- The student is not studying English as a Second Language.
- The student's proposed employment relates to the student's major area of study. For more information see [SEVP Policy Guidance: Practical Training – Determining a Direct Relationship between Employment and a Student's Major Area of Study](#).
- The student has not used all optional practical training available at the current level of study.
- The student has not been authorized for 12 months or more of full-time Curricular Practical Training (CPT).

Full-time CPT at a previous school at the same program level counts toward the CPT 12-month total affecting OPT. CPT at another program level does not affect OPT.

OPT Process at a Glance

Remind your F-1 students:

- Not to file the Form I-765, “Application for Employment Authorization,” until you have recommended OPT in their SEVIS records, and they have the updated Form I-20 with the OPT recommendation.
- They must file within the 30-day period after your DSO OPT recommendation.

If a student submits the Form I-765 on paper or electronically before you recommend the OPT or after the 30-day post-DSO recommendation period:

- USCIS will deny the application. (Federal regulations require the DSO OPT recommendation on the student SEVIS record before the Form I-765 is submitted.)
- The student will lose the application fee.
- The student will have to reapply for OPT and pay the fee again.

IMPORTANT: Making these mistakes can dramatically delay the final USCIS authorized OPT start date.

The OPT application process involves many players and

several steps:

Step	Users Actions
1	Student follows school processes to submit an OPT request to the DSO.
2	• DSO confirms eligibility, enters the request in SEVIS and issues the Form I-20. • DSO signs the Form I-20 and gives to the student. • Status of the OPT request in SEVIS immediately changes to Requested. Note: Any OPT status updates to SEVIS are automatic and require no action on the part of the DSO.
3	Required paperwork: • Student signs the Form I-20. • Student completes an Application for Employment Authorization (Form I-765). The Form I-765, fee, and supporting documentation must be filed with USCIS within 30 days of the DSO's recommendation. Note: The Form I-765 is available on the USCIS website http://www.uscis.gov/i-765. The web site provides submission instructions.

4	• Upon receipt of the Form I-765, USCIS issues a Receipt Notice (Form I-797) that contains the receipt number assigned to the case. • Through an interface with USCIS, the status of the OPT request in SEVIS changes to Pending. • If USCIS needs more information, the student will receive a Request For Evidence (RFE), which states what information is needed and the deadline for submitting it. The student must respond by the deadline. • USCIS then makes a decision on the application: • If the application is approved, USCIS issues an EAD and the OPT Request status in SEVIS changes to Approved. • If the Form I-765 is denied, the OPT Request status in SEVIS changes to Denied.
5	• Student receives the EAD and can begin work once the authorized date arrives. • When the student is hired, the student reports the employer information to the DSO. Note: While on OPT, the student must

	report to the DSO within 10 days any changes in the student’s name or address, and employment information.
6	DSO must update SEVIS within 21 days with the employment information and any name or address changes.

Any F-1 Optional Practical Training request in Requested status longer than 180 days is automatically canceled by SEVIS.

Form I-765 Filing Deadlines Once DSO Requests OPT in SEVIS

Day 1	Day 30	After Day 30
• DSO requests OPT in SEVIS • 30-day countdown begins	• 30-day countdown ends • USCIS must receive the application	• Applications received by USCIS after day 30 will be denied

If the student does not file a Form I-765, the DSO should cancel the OPT request in SEVIS.

Recommend Optional Practical Training

DSOs must be mindful of several key dates when entering OPT in SEVIS.

Key Dates

DSOs must be mindful of several key dates when entering OPT in SEVIS.

[Post-Completion OPT](#)

[Planning Tool](#): This Excel spreadsheet allows users to calculate the amount of OPT available for a student and generates suggested timelines for a student, based on the Program End Date and the desired OPT start date.

Recommend OPT

- SEVIS will not allow DSOs to request overlapping segments of OPT. You must specify if the OPT is pre-completion or post-completion OPT and must be either full or part-time.
- DSOs should verify and, if necessary, shorten the program end date on the Form I-20 before recommending a student for post-completion OPT
- If a DSO is recommending OPT for a student who plans to split their OPT time between degree programs at the same education level, you should explicitly note in SEVIS that the student is requesting to split their OPT time. The requested OPT validity dates for each particular degree

program should be limited to the planned duration of OPT for that program.

To recommend OPT:

1. Go to the *Student Information* page.
2. Click **OPT Request**. The *OPT Employment* page opens.

3. Click **New OPT Request**. The *Add OPT Employment* page opens.

4. Enter information relevant to the OPT authorization.

Field	Description
-------	-------------

The student has met or will meet the one full academic year requirement by the employment start date.	• Click the checkbox to indicate the student has met the enrollment requirement. • This is a required field.
*OPT Type	• Select either: • Pre-Completion: All employment occurs before the Program End Date. • Post-Completion: All employment occurs after the Program End Date. • This is a required field.
*Full-Time/Part-Time	• Select either: • Part-Time: Select if Pre-Completion OPT occurs when school is in session. • Full-Time: Select full-time if: • Pre-Completion OPT occurs when school is not in session.

	• Employment is Post-Completion OPT. • This is a required field.
*Start Date	• The date that OPT authorization starts. • This date cannot be before the student has completed one academic year of full-time study • A student can split their OPT time between degree programs at the same education level (for example, they intend to use six months of OPT after completing a master of fine arts degree and the remaining six months of OPT after completing a master of music degree). • The requested OPT validity dates for each particular degree program should be limited to the planned duration of OPT for that program. If the student would like to request less than the maximum validity period of post-completion OPT available for each degree program, you should explicitly note in SEVIS that the student

	is requesting to split their OPT time. • If you initially request 12 months of OPT based on one degree program, the student will be unable to later request OPT based on a different degree program at the same education level. Format: MM/DD/YYYY. Post-Completion OPT: Start Date must be on or after the Program End Date. It cannot be more than 60 days after the Program End Date. • This is a required field.
*End Date	• The date the OPT authorization is to end. Format: MM/DD/YYYY • Pre-Completion OPT: Cannot be after the Program End Date. • Post-Completion OPT: Cannot enter a date more than 12 months after the Employment Start Date. • This is a required field.
	Enter or update remarks regarding

Student Remarks	the student's planned employment. Use this field to convey important information you think the student or government officials need to know. USCIS has noted they want to see how the planned employment relates to the student's major course of study. For example: student will pursue training .related to studies. This field is limited to 1,000 characters. Note: Comments entered here overwrite any existing remarks that print in the Remarks field on Page 1 of the Form I-20.
Employment Remarks	• Enter any applicable remarks about the student's employment. This field is limited to 250 characters. • These remarks do not print on the Form I-20.

5. Review the information. Click either **Save** or **Cancel**:

- **Cancel:** Returns to the *OPT Employment* page without saving.
- **Save:** Submits the OPT request. An *Update Successful* message displays.

To recommend an additional period of OPT, click **New OPT Request** and repeat Steps 4 and 5.

The start and end dates for segments of OPT cannot overlap.

6. Click either **Print I-20** or **Return to Employment List**:

- **Print I-20**: Prints the Form I-20 with the OPT recommendation.

- Once the Certificate of Eligibility (Form I-20) has been submitted, the DSO must sign page one of the form.
 - Form I-20 is given to the student.
 - Find more information on allowable electronic signatures and Form I-20 transmission in SEVP's policy guidance [Use of Electronic Signatures and Transmission for the Form I-20](#).
-
- **Return to Employment List:** Returns the user to the *OPT Employment* page. The newly added OPT employment will be on the list.

7. Review the information on the *OPT Employment* page. To make changes to the existing OPT request, **click** [Edit](#). (See Edit OPT Request below for detailed edit instructions.)
8. Click either **Print I-20** or **Return**:
 - **Print I-20**: Prints the Form I-20.
 - **Return**: Returns the user to the Student Information page.

Edit OPT Request

OPT information can be edited depending on the status of the OPT request:

Request Status	Editable Fields
Requested	• Full-time/Part-time • Fulfillment of 1-year requirement • Employment Remarks • Student Remarks
Pending	• Full-time/Part-time • Fulfillment of 1-year requirement • Employment Remarks • Student Remarks
Approved	• Employer Name • Employer Address • Explanation for relationship to course work • Employment Remarks • Student Remarks

To edit an OPT request:

1. Click **OPT Request** on the *Student Information* page.
The *OPT Employment* page opens.

2. Click **Edit** to the right of the OPT segment to be edited.
The *Edit OPT Employment* page opens.

3. Make any necessary edits:

Field	Description

*The student has met or will meet the one full academic year requirement by the employment start date.	• Click the checkbox to indicate the student has met the enrollment requirement. • This is a required field.
*Full-Time/Part-Time	Select either: • Part-Time: Select if Pre-Completion OPT occurs when school is in session. • Full-Time: Select full-time if: • Pre-Completion OPT occurs when school is not in session. • Employment is Post-Completion OPT. • This is a required field.
Student Remarks	Enter or update remarks regarding the student. Note: Comments entered here overwrite any existing remarks that print in the Remarks field

	on page one of the Form I-20.
Employment Remarks	Enter any applicable remarks about the student's employment.

4. Click either **Save** or **Cancel**:

- **Cancel**: Returns the user to the OPT Employment page without updating the employment segment.
- **Save**: Updates this employment request in the student's record. An **Update Successful** message indicates if the edit was successful. Click either **Print I-20** or **Return to Employment List**:

- **Print I 20**: Prints the Form I-20 with the OPT recommendation.

- Once the Certificate of Eligibility (Form I-20) has been submitted, the DSO must sign page one of the form.
 - Form I-20 is given to the student.
 - Find more information on allowable electronic signatures and Form I-20 transmission in SEVP's policy guidance [Use of Electronic Signatures and Transmission for the Form I-20](#).
-
- **Return to Employment List:** Returns to the *OPT Employment* page.

Cancel/Withdraw OPT Request

An OPT request can be canceled in SEVIS **ONLY** if the OPT Request is in Requested status.

OPT REQUEST STATUS IN SEVIS = Requested	OPT REQUEST STATUS IN SEVIS = Pending
• P/DSO can cancel OPT in SEVIS. • OPT request status changes to Canceled. • Do not cancel OPT request if the student has mailed the Form I-765 to USCIS.	• P/DSO cannot cancel OPT in SEVIS. • Student must write USCIS to withdraw the Form I-765. • After processing by USCIS, OPT request status in SEVIS changes to Withdrawn.

Cancel OPT Request

To cancel an OPT request:

1. Go to the *Student Information* page.
2. Click **OPT Request**. The *OPT Employment* page opens.

3. Click **Cancel Request** next to the segment of OPT you want to cancel. A *Confirm Cancelation of Request* page opens.

4. Click either **Yes** or **No**:

- **No:** Returns the user to the OPT Employment page without canceling the OPT request.
- **Yes:** Cancels the OPT request. An Update Successful message verifies that the update was successful.

Click either **Return to Employment List** or **Print I-20**:

- Click **Print I-20** to print the Form I-20.
- Click **Return to Employment List** to return to the *OPT Employment page*; and then click either **Return** or **Print I-20**:
 - Click **Print I-20** to print the Form I-20.
 - Click **Return** to return to the *Student Information page*.

The student's OPT status in the Student Requests section updates to Canceled.

Withdraw OPT Request

Once an OPT request status changes to Pending, the student must write USCIS to withdraw the OPT application. The request must:

- Be sent to the USCIS Service Center processing the application. The address is on the USCIS-issued Receipt Notice sent to the student.
- Include the receipt number USCIS assigned the case when it was filed.

Report OPT Participation

While on OPT, a student is required to report the following to their DSO:

- Change in student's legal name.
- Change in student's address while on OPT.
- Changes in employment or interruption of employment.

Students can enter employment information using the SEVP Portal or DSOs can update SEVIS to reflect the changes. Employment information must be updated in a timely manner.



For additional
related
information, see:

- 8 CFR 214.2(f)
(12)(ii)(E)
- [SEVP OPT
Policy
Guidance](#)
- [F-1 Add, Edit,
Delete
Optional
Practical
Training_\(OPT\).
Employer](#)
- [View
Employment
Information](#)
- [Unemployment
Counter](#)
- [SEVIS and the
SEVP Portal](#)
- [SEVP Portal
Student User
Guide](#)

DSOs are expected to add, edit, or delete employer information in a timely manner.

Post-completion OPT and Unemployment

While students are not required to have an employer when OPT is requested in SEVIS, students authorized for post-completion OPT are expected to be employed. A student on post-completion OPT can be unemployed for a total of 90 days.

- A student whose record lacks employer information is considered unemployed.
- SEVP officials can manually terminate a student who accrues 90 total days of unemployment.
- See the [Unemployment Counter](#) article on the SEVIS Help Hub for more information.

OPT-Related SEVIS Alerts and Lists

The following Alert List and Student Lists in SEVIS help DSOs monitor and manage students on OPT:

Alert/List	Description
Accrued Unemployment Days for Students on Approved OPT or STEM	This Alert List shows: • SEVIS ID • Surname/Primary Name • Given Name • OPT Type (Post-completion or STEM OPT) • OPT Actual Start Date • OPT Actual End Date • Currently Employed • The number of days of unemployment allowed • The number of days of unemployment used • The number of days of unemployment remaining Note: All employer start and end dates must be within the employment actual start and end dates. If employer dates fall outside the actual start and end

	dates the student will appear on this list and as unemployed.
Students with Requested, Pending, or Approved Optional Practical Training (OPT)	This Student List shows: • Active indicator • SEVIS ID • Visa Type • Surname/Primary Name • Given Name • DSO Recommended Start and End Dates • Actual OPT Start and End Dates • Student's Email Address • OPT Type • Request Status • Receipt Number
Students Terminated for Exceeding the Maximum Number of Days of Unemployment	This Student List shows: • SEVIS ID • Class of Admission • Surname/Primary Name • Given Name • Termination Date • OPT Type

View OPT Employment Information

DSOs can view a student's OPT information on the following pages, which are accessed through the View section of the Student Information page:

- *Request/Authorization Details* page: Lists only current authorizations.
- *Employment Information* page: Lists all employment authorizations linked to the SEVIS ID.

For additional related information, see [View Employment Information](#).

H-1B Cap-Gap Extension of OPT

SEVIS will automatically extend post-completion OPT or 24-month science, technology, engineering, and math (STEM) extension of OPT if:

- On or after April 1, an employer files an eligible H-1B petition to change the student's status.
- The requested start date for the H-1B is October 1.
- The student's OPT or 17-month OPT extension ends on or after April 1.
- Review the [F-1 Cap Gap Extension](#) article for information on how to add or edit cap gap information on a record.

Correcting OPT Data: Correction Requests and Data Fixes

If OPT information in SEVIS does not reflect applications filed with or decisions made by USCIS, DSOs can ask to have the record corrected. There are two ways to correct data in a student record.

Method	What Can be Fixed
<u>Correction Request</u>	This option is used to request changes (using SEVIS) for the following: • Status of OPT Request. • Employment Start Date. • Employment End Date.
SRC Ticket (Data Fix)	This option is used for more complicated issues and requires DSOs to contact the SEVP Response Center (SRC) via phone at 703-603-3400 or 1-800-892-4829, or via email at SEVP@ice.dhs.gov. Types of OPT-related data fixes include: • Adding retroactive OPT to a record. • Changing the OPT request status for an OPT request that is already in Approved status. • Any data fix that cannot be submitted in a correction request.

WHAT'S NEW

Try the Facebook Chatbot

Visit the tool on the Study in the States Facebook page to learn how to become an F or M international student in the United States.

[Read more on the blog](#)

Learn About Summer Employment

While employed this summer, make sure you have all the relevant information on maintaining your student status, and the steps you must take before returning to school.

[Read more on the blog](#)

ICON GUIDE

See the [SEVIS Help Icons](#) on the SEVIS Help Hub for a quick-reference of the icons used in this user guide.

I'm Looking For

CONTACT US

SEVP Response
Center

703-603-3400

Monday -Friday
8:00 a.m. to 6:00
p.m. ET,
except holidays

SEVP@ice.dhs.gov

ICE Tip Line

[1-866-DHS-2-ICE](tel:1-866-DHS-2-ICE)

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